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The Many Faces of Nationalism

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> You want proof that the sun exists, so you stay up/ All night talking about it. Finally you sleep/ As the sun comes up.
>
> —Jelaluddin Balkhi ‘Rumi’

On 13 December 2001, the entire country watched the attack on the Indian Parliament on their TV screens. We all saw the bloodied faces of the five attackers killed by our security forces. The country went into a state of shock. No one questioned the government’s story that the attack was the handiwork of Pakistan- based terrorists belonging to the Lashkar-e-Toiba and Jaish-e-Mohammad. The media, in a willing suspension of disbelief, published whatever the police and investigating agencies put out.

The police completed its entire investigation in a record time of one week and quickly arrested four people—three Kashmiri men and a Sikh woman—for helping the five deceased attackers. The police forced Mohammad Afzal to cooperate with them. He, apparently, led them to the hide-outs of the five attackers and the shops from where they had purchased mobile phones, cash cards and chemicals for making bombs. Under torture, in police custody, Afzal later ‘confessed’.

The Special Branch organized a press conference on 20 December at the Lodhi Road Police Station and produced Mohammad Afzal before the national media. In full view of the nation, Afzal confessed to being part of the conspiracy to attack Parliament.[1] One effect of this ‘media trial’ was that the public no longer felt the need for a ‘judicial trial’. Since everyone in the country knew who had attacked our Parliament, where was the need for formal proof?

The media trial also served a political purpose. The government stood vindicated in the world arena with the international community finally forced